order to enhance the relative voice of others is wholly foreign to the First Amendment, which was designed "to secure 'the widest possible dissemination of information from diverse and antagonistic sources,' " and " 'to assure unfettered interchange of ideas for the bringing about of political and social changes desired by the people.' " *New York Times Co.* v. *Sullivan, supra,* at 266, 269, quoting *Associated Press* v. *United States,* 326 U. S. 1, 20 (1945), and *Roth* v. *United States,* 354 U. S., at 484. The First Amendment's protection against governmental abridgment of free expression cannot properly be made to depend on a person's financial ability to engage in public discussion. Cf. *Eastern R. Conf.* v. *Noerr Motors,* 365 U. S. 127, 139 (1961).[55]

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[55] Neither the voting rights cases nor the Court's decision upholding the Federal Communications Commission's fairness doctrine lends support to appellees' position that the First Amendment permits Congress to abridge the rights of some persons to engage in political expression in order to enhance the relative voice of other segments of our society.

Cases invalidating governmentally imposed wealth restrictions on the right to vote or file as a candidate for public office rest on the conclusion that wealth "is not germane to one's ability to participate intelligently in the electoral process" and is therefore an insufficient basis on which to restrict a citizen's fundamental right to vote. *Harper* v. *Virginia Bd. of Elections,* 383 U. S. 663, 668 (1966). See *Lubin* v. *Panish,* 415 U. S. 709 (1974); *Bullock* v. *Carter,* 405 U. S. 134 (1972); *Phoenix* v. *Kolodziejski,* 399 U. S. 204 (1970). These voting cases and the reapportionment decisions serve to assure that citizens are accorded an equal right to vote for their representatives regardless of factors of wealth or geography. But the principles that underlie invalidation of governmentally imposed restrictions on the franchise do not justify governmentally imposed restrictions on political expression. Democracy depends on a well-informed electorate, not a citizenry legislatively limited in its ability to discuss and debate candidates and issues.

In *Red Lion Broadcasting Co.* v. *FCC,* 395 U. S. 367 (1969), the Court upheld the political-editorial and personal-attack portions of